

Mains Master Program 2024: Art and Culture (GS1)

Handout 2: Eras and Dynasties

Q. “Mauryans made a remarkable contribution to Indian art and architecture.” Elaborate.

Mauryan Empire, India's first subcontinental empire in the 3rd c BCE, provided royal patronage to create a highly refined art and architecture. Because of this, there was a re-emergence of monumental art in India after a gap of more than 1500 years.

Features/Aspects of Mauryan Art:

- **A variety of structural remains** from Mauryan era attest to diversity of patronage.
 - **Palace Art:** Linked to political ideology and thus Uniformity of style and purpose.
 - Religious
 - Stupas (eg Vaishali stupa, Sanchi stupa, Dharmarajika stupa)
 - Rock-cut architecture (eg Barabar and Nagarjuni Caves)
 - Pillars and pillar capitals (eg Lion Capital at Sarnath)
 - Royal: 80 Pillared Hall, wooden palisade at Kumarahar, Bulandibagh (Pataliputra)
 - **Popular Art:** Diversity of form and intent, spread across population centres.
 - Didarganj Yakshi, Parkham Yakshas
- **Evolved technical features:**
 - **Massive use of stone:** It was a departure from the earlier use of wood. This is likely due to the political and economic prosperity, Mauryans could quarry and transport of large stones.
 - **Monolithic Structures:** The Ashokan pillars were carved out of a single piece of stone. This technique required exceptional craftsmanship and engineering skills.
 - **Polished surfaces:** Unlike Harappan era textured sculptures, polished surface on Mauryan art appears more elegant.
- **Iconography:**
 - Mauryan art incorporated symbolic elements to project **royal ideology** as well as depict **Buddhist ideals**. For example, lions symbolizing royal power as well as Buddhism on Ashokan capital.
- **Diverse Subject-matter:**
 - **Animal sculptures** are a common feature of Mauryan art. These sculptures often depict animals such as lions, elephants, and bulls. In comparison, **human figures** are less common.
 - Plants, leaves and various geometric **motifs** were often used to **decorate** pillar capitals.
 - Ashoka's Edicts, carved in Brahmi script are the **earliest example of calligraphy** in Indian subcontinent.
- **Mauryan Style:**
 - **Monumentality:** Grand and monumental structures.
 - **Symmetry:** Mauryan art is often symmetrical, with balanced compositions and repeated motifs.
 - **Exceptionally fine aesthetic ideals:** Didarganj Yakshi, Nude torso of a Digambar monk.

- **Realism:** The most distinctive feature of Mauryan style is that the artists strived to convey a sense of lifelike appearance and naturalism in their creations. While animal figures are typically realistic, humans were generally stylized.

Thus, Mauryan art represents a great transformation and innovation in Indian art, and it laid the foundation for the development of later Indian art styles.

Q. Can we characterize the period of 5 centuries after the decline of Mauryas as the dark age of Indian history?

The term "dark age" implies a period of political fragmentation, cultural backwardness, and societal regression. Originally, the post-Mauryan period (200 BCE to 300 CE) was termed as Dark Age but in light of comprehensive analysis, the use of this label is suspect.

Logic of Dark Age:

- **Political Fragmentation:** After the decline of Mauryas, there was political fragmentation which led to constant state of conflict between various smaller states. This instability led to weaker central governments, and the absence of long-lasting peace. Presumably it led to the economic and cultural regression as well.
- **Foreign Invasions:** In the Northwest India, there were continuous invasions of various foreign ethnic groups like Indo-Greeks, Shakas, Parthians and Kushanas. Thus, large part of India was under foreign occupation.

However, on closer scrutiny, one finds that instead of being a dark age, these centuries were rather full of political, cultural, economic, intellectual, and artistic progress.

- **Political landscape:**
 - While regional powers remain strong and conflict characterized this era, it is important to recognize that such scenario is not an anomaly in India's history. Rather, in this era, there was the emergence of the first states throughout India: in South India (Chera, Chola, Pandya), Deccan (Satavahanas) and East (Kharevala). Beginning of new types of Prashasti inscriptions attest to the fact of entrenching of monarchy in various parts of India. Moreover, the absence of one unified empire doesn't necessarily mean economic or cultural regression.
 - All the foreign invaders were quickly Indianized, accepted either Hinduism or Buddhism. They soon became the great patrons of Indian culture (eg Nahapana patronized Karle cave)
- **Economy:**
 - The urbanization from Ganga valley now started to spread throughout India.
 - All regions in India came under monetized economy for the first time.
 - It was an era of intense trade with both the Roman empire and SE Asia, as well as with China via Silk Route.

- **Religions:**
 - Idol worship and bhakti started to enter the high culture of Buddhism, Hinduism and Jainism.
 - Emergence of extremely influential Mahayana Buddhism.
 - Philosophically, there were various Abhidhamma texts.
 - Crystallization and spread of Vaishnavism, Shaivism.
- **Art and Cultural:**
 - The process of Aryanization of South India started in this era.
 - Sanskrit language started to become the court language.
 - Profuse Literature in Sanskrit, Tamil and Prakrit: Sangam literature, Manusmriti and Yajnavalkya Smriti, Patanjali's Mahabhashya, Ashvaghosha's drama, Milindapanho, Bharatamuni's Natyashastra, Gatha Saptashati
 - Popular form of Buddhism led to the spread of Stupa cult (eg Sanchi, Amaravati) and rock-cut cave (eg. Bhaja cave) architecture throughout India.
 - Creation of new artforms like Gandhara and Mathura style of sculpture
- **External influence:** Continuing Mauryan tradition, India emerged as a cultural soft power. Indian culture was not inward looking or defensive in this era, it expanded to various regions.
 - We find presence of Vaishnavism in Central Asia.
 - Silk route became the conduit of spread of Buddhism throughout Asia due to Kushana.

Therefore, it would be more appropriate to consider the post-Mauryan period as a phase which created the **foundation for the Golden Age during the Gupta era.**

Q. The Gupta period has often been referred to as “Golden Age” due to its cultural heritage. Do you agree?

The Gupta period (c. 320–550 CE) is often referred to as the "Golden Age" of India due to its high political achievements, socio-economic development and great cultural heritage.

Golden Age:

- **Political unity and stability:**

- During the Gupta Empire, there was political unification of large part of India, almost after 500 years of fragmentation.
- It was a period of relative peace and enlightened monarchs, who patronized the flourishing of art, literature, and science.

- **Economic prosperity:**

- The developed agriculture, crafts like textile and metallurgy, and international trade created urban prosperity as attested by the highly refined gold coins of Gupta era.

- **Religious tolerance:**

- During this time, the Puranic religion became mainstream, assimilating within the great tradition various regional and tribal cultures. It created a tolerant and pluralistic culture.
- The epics Ramayana and Mahabharata are believed to have been compiled and given their final form around 4th-5th century CE.
- Moreover, there was mutual respect for Buddhism and Jainism as well, which is evident from various inscriptions.

- **Intellectual advancement:** Major contributions were made in all aspects of intellectual life.

- Development of the decimal system and the idea of Zero by Aryabhata.
- Medical knowledge of surgery in Sushruta Samhita.
- Advancement of astronomy and astrology by astronomer Varahamihira.

- **Cultural patronage:** The Gupta rulers were great patrons of the arts.

- Beginning of the construction of temples. Eg Dashavatara Temple at Deogarh
- Beautiful Ajanta Cave paintings, patronized by Vakatakas, are the high point of ancient mural tradition.
- Superb sculptural craftsmanship in the form of Sarnath Buddha.
- Classical Sanskrit reached its pinnacle with exceptionally fine literature of Kalidasa, who is known as Shakespeare of India. There was all-round flourishing of Sanskrit in secular as well as religious literature.

- **Cultural diffusion:** During this era, Indian culture spread to other parts of Asia, like China and Southeast Asia.

Thus, Gupta period was considered as time of great cultural and intellectual achievement by past historians. However, it seems that these achievements were exaggerated by such historians. The label of the "golden age" is not completely correct, as there were some problems. **In reality,**

- **Political:** The Gupta Empire was not as large or as centralized as Mauryans. In later era, it was also marked by political instability (invasion by Hunas).
- **Economic:** The extent of foreign trade and urbanization started to reduce in Gupta era and there was increasing reliance of agriculture.

- **Social:** The cultural flourishing observed during the Gupta period was limited to certain urban centers and the elite classes, while the majority of the population didn't experience such prosperity. The varna system and patriarchal social norms continued. Fa Hien and Huen Tsang inform us about the condition of untouchables.

The truth is that one must accept that there is no era in the past which is completely golden for all the people and regions. Such labels romanticize/idealize the past and neglect complexities. Thus, we need to appreciate great cultural and intellectual achievements of Gupta era while keeping in mind the limits of such 'golden-ness'.

Practice Questions:

Q. In what ways did the Gupta classical Age set the foundation for subsequent developments in Indian history?

Q. How did the Gupta classical age influence the development of later Indian art, literature, and science?

Q. The strength and vigour of Indian history lay south of the Vindhyas between 500-750 CE. Discuss Critically.

After the decline of the Gupta empire, North India presented a picture of political fragmentation, characterised by rising feudalism, decline of trade, demonetisation and de-urbanisation. On the other hand, South of the Vindhyas, two big empires emerged, Chalukyas of Badami and Pallavas of Kanchipuram. Apart from political achievements, there was also significant social, economic, and cultural growth.

- This period represented the **second urbanisation in the deep South**.
- Not only **Sanskrit** was patronized, but it was also the period when **Tamil Bhakti** emerged as a popular movement. A new Tamil identity emerged as a result of both the assimilation of and reaction against northern culture. In Deccan, there was a beginning of ascendancy of **Kannada language** due to royal patronage.
- There were many **educational** centres like **Kanchipuram** which thrived.
- In the field of visual arts – both Badami/Aihole/Pattadakal as well as Mahabalipuram represented the **cradle of Indian temple architecture**, that flourished in medieval times.

However, upon closer observation, a different picture appears. The north was not as weak as it appears.

- **Politically**, rulers such as Harshvardhan, Yashovarman, and Lalitaditya established large empires, won significant military victories and provided sound administration.
- **Economically**, it appears that following the repulsion of the Hunas, North India witnessed a revival of trade with the West, especially after the Arab conquest of Sindh. The flourishing urban economy of North India is reflected in Huiyen Tsang's commentary, about large cities such as Kannauj and Prayagraj.
- Lastly, major developments were witnessed in the field of religion due to the emergence of new devotional cults and practices such as **Bhakti** and **Tantricism**.
- In the **cultural sphere** as well, North India continued to exhibit excellence.
 - Huiyen Tsang has painted a picture of **religious diversity and harmony** in which the secular state continued to **heavily patronise both cultural and religious activities**.
 - The post Gupta period witnessed the emergence and continued growth of premier **educational institutions** such as Vallabhi, Sharda Peeth, and Nalanda.

Therefore, to claim that the strength and vigour of Indian history had completely shifted beyond the Vindhyas would be an oversimplification.

Moreover, the very idea that historical development can stop in a particular region is inherently flawed. Such concepts need to be given a fresh up appraisal.

Practice Question

Q. How did the foundation of Pallava and Chalukyan state herald a new era in the history of south India?

Q. What are the characteristics of religion and culture in India during the era of feudalism in early medieval?

The early medieval period in India is considered as the era of feudalism (600-1200 CE). In this era, as the society became more stratified, politics became regionally oriented, and economy became agrarian, there were significant changes in the field of religion and culture as well. Practices of patronage to regional language and temple, land grants to priests etc influenced the entire field of culture and religion.

Characteristics of Religious landscape:

- Compilation and propagation of **Puranas**, which narrated stories of gods, goddesses, and cosmology, played a significant role in shaping religious beliefs. They carried the process of **Sanskritization**, whereby local deities and practices were incorporated into mainstream Hinduism.
- The **rise of the Bhakti movement** emphasized personal devotion to deities, making religion more accessible to the common people. Saints like Alvars and Nayanars in South India popularized this movement. Still, the social hierarchy of caste system continued to remain deeply entrenched.
- There was **extensive construction of temples** across India, which became centers of worship, culture, and social activities.
- **Different sects** within Hinduism, such as Shaivism and Vaishnavism, became more distinct and organized. Each had its own set of rituals, temples, and followers.
- Worship of **local deities** and incorporation of **folk traditions** into mainstream became common, leading to popularization of **Tantric practices** in every religion.
- **Buddhism**, once a dominant religion, saw a decline. **Jainism** continued to thrive, particularly in Western India, under the patronage of various regional rulers.

Characteristics of Cultural landscape:

- With fragmented political power, **regional languages and cultural identities** grew stronger.
- **Rulers often acted as patrons** of temples and religious institutions, seeking **legitimacy** and strengthening their rule. They patronized poets and scholars, leading to the production of **courtly literature**.
- **Temples and mutts served as centers of education**. Nalanda and Vikramashila universities continued to attract scholars from various regions.
- **Sanskrit continued** to be a dominant language for scholarly and literary works, with significant contributions in poetry, drama, and philosophy. Still, there was **the rise of regional languages** such as Tamil, Kannada, Telugu, and Marathi. Works in these languages often had religious themes, including **devotional poetry and narratives**.
- **Distinct architectural styles** evolved, such as the Dravidian style in the South and the Nagara style in the North. Famous examples include the Brihadeeswarar Temple in Thanjavur and the Khajuraho temples.
- The period is known for **elaborate sculptures** adorning temples, depicting deities, mythological scenes, and daily life. There was a **refinement in the iconography** of deities, with detailed and symbolic representations becoming more **standardized**.
- **Classical forms of dance and music**, which had religious and ritualistic significance, were patronized by both royal courts and temples. Bharatanatyam in the South and Odissi in the East are examples of dance forms that evolved during this period.

Thus, during the relatively regionalized and inward looking early medieval India, there regional diversity in religious practices, language and culture.

Practice Questions:

Q. 11th and 12th c CE saw eventful progression in cultural history. Discuss.

Q. In spite of political upheavals, Rajput period is marked by uncommon cultural upsurge. Comment.



Q. Discuss the Rashtrakuta contribution to art and culture.

The Rashtrakutas, who ruled parts of present-day India from around the 8th to the 10th centuries, made significant contributions to art and culture, especially in the Deccan region.

Religious Patronage: The Rashtrakuta dynasty played a pivotal role in promoting and supporting various religious traditions during their reign.

- The Rashtrakuta rulers were instrumental in **popularising the worship of Shiva and Vishnu**, which led to the widespread acceptance of Shaivism and Vaishnavism across their realm.
- They also followed a **policy of tolerance** including religious freedom to Arab Muslim settlers, who married local women, resulting in the growth of the Moplah community.

Literary Patronage: The Rashtrakutas were great patrons of Sanskrit and Jain literature:

- Rashtrakutas significantly contributed to **Sanskrit** literature:
 - Trivikrama wrote works like Nalachampu.
 - Halayudha composed the Kavirahasya.
 - Sakatayana authored the grammar work known as Amogavritti.
- **Jain** literature thrived under their patronage:
 - Amogavarsha I supported Jain scholars, including Jinasena who wrote Parsvabhudaya.
 - Gunabhadra authored the Adipurana, detailing the lives of Jain saints.
 - Jain Mathematician Mahaviracharya contributed with Ganitasara-sangraha.
- The Rashtrakuta era marked the emergence of **Kannada literature**:
 - Amogavarsha's Kavirajamarga became the first poetic work in Kannada.
 - **Pampa, Ponna, and Ranna** were prominent Kannada scholars during their reign.
 - Pampa's Vikramasena-vijaya was a notable work, and Ponna wrote Shantipurana.

Art and Architecture:

- **Ellora** features the iconic Kailasha temple, carved from a single rock, showcasing Dravidian characteristics. It includes a three-tiered shikhara and intricate sculptures of Hindu deities and mythological scenes.
- **Elephanta's** sculptures depict Shiva in various forms, reflecting Rashtrakuta craftsmanship and artistic prowess.
- Rashtrakuta rulers like Krishna III contributed temples at **Rameshwaram**, such as the Krishneshwar temple, Gan Markand temple and the Ditya temple

Thus, the Rashtrakutas' contributions in literature, art, architecture, and religious patronage enriched the cultural landscape of early medieval India.

Practice Question:

Q. Pala period is the most significant phase in the history of Buddhism in India. Enumerate.

Q. The Chola rulers were not only mighty conquerors, efficient administrators but also builders of the temples. Comment.

In the history of India, the achievements of Chola dynasty to both political as well culture fields was outstanding.

Conquerors:

- Cholas created **vast empire** spreading across South India.
- Emperors like Rajaraja and Rajendra spread Chola influence even outside India, when India itself being invaded, and defeated all neighbours.
 - They subdued Srilankan king, successfully carried naval expedition to Shailendra king and converted the Bay of Bengal into Chola lake.
 - The north Indian expedition reached till Bengal.

Efficient administrators:

- Chola created a state which was centralized at the upper level and provided local autonomy at the local self-government.
- There was elaborate administrative machinery comprising various officials called perundanam and sirudanam. The kings undertook royal tours to increase the efficiency of the administration.
- New admin units like velanadus, brahmadeya/agrahars, nagarams etc made their presence felt.
- The system of village autonomy with sabhas and their committees reached its culmination during the Chola rule as mentioned in Uttamerur inscription.

Builders of temple

- Architectural achievements applauded by scholars. **James Fergusson** said that Cholan artists conceived like giants and finished like jewelers.
- Built number of temples, but Brihadeshwara, Gangaikondacholapuram point to the remarkable workmanship.
 - Here, Chola artists were trend-setters with new styles like lofty vimanas, started gopurams, larger mandapas became defining features of Dravidian style.
 - Brihadeeshwar Temple considered as one of the largest temples of India, it is exclusively built by granite.
- Focus on massive sculptures – Nandi, Lingam, Stupi etc
- Its influence may also be seen in Srilanka and SE Asian kingdoms. Rajaraja I himself constructed a Shiva temple at Polanuruva at Sri Lanka in the same pattern of Chola architecture.

Thus, the Chola period was an age of continuous improvement and refinement of culture and the Dravidian style reached its perfection under the Cholas.

OR

Thus, strong military, able administration & good governance by Cholas provided ample surplus, expertise & acumen to execute the large-scale marvels like Brihadisvara Temple.

Q. Write a note on salient features of Chola art.

Chola art, which flourished in south India during 9th-13th c., is known for its grandeur and exquisite craftsmanship, which encompassed various forms such as temple architecture, bronze casting, stone sculpture and wall painting.

- **Visual Arts**

- Chola architecture is the **high watermark of Dravidian style**, characterized by pyramidal vimanas, beautiful mandapas, elaborate gopurams, ornate pillars, prakaram and pushkarinis surrounding temples, sculptures of deities on the outer walls, and detailed ornamentation. Prominent examples include the Brihadeshvara Temple in Thanjavur and the Airavatesvara Temple in Darasuram.
- Chola temples housed **large, sculpted panels** depicting deities, celestial beings, and mythological narratives.
- Chola **bronze casting**, using lox-wax method was renowned for its technical skill and artistic finesse. Though following the traditional iconographic conventions, the sculptors achieved a **classic grace and grandeur**. The best example of this can be seen in the form of Nataraja the Divine Dancer. *They are also highly sought after in international smuggling networks.*
- Chola art also included **vibrant and colorful murals** on temple walls. Examples can still be found in temples like the Brihadeshvara Temple.

- **Literary Arts:** Huge patronage to both Tamil and Sanskrit by Chola kings led to thriving literary culture of the era. Variety of works – both religious and secular – were composed which are renowned for their classicism even today.

- Jivaka Chintamani, a Tamil Epic by Tirutakkadevar (a Jain ascetic) in 10th c
- Compilation of Shaiva canon Tirumurai by Nambi Andar Nambi during Rajaraja Chola
- Addition of 12th Tirumurai called Periyapuram by Sekkilar
- Tamil Ramayana composed by Kambar (masterpiece) during Kulottunga III

- **Performing Arts**

- Nritya Mandapa
- Karana Mudras

Q. Describe the idea of the composite culture in India as developed during the era of the Delhi Sultanate/Mughal Empire.

OR

Underline the contribution of Delhi Sultanate/Mughals to the cultural heritage of India.

Despite initial antagonism after the establishment of Delhi sultanate, there soon emerged a composite culture with amalgamation of diverse cultural-religious-artistic traditions, due to inevitable interactions between the two communities and ruling elites.

OR

The process of assimilation of Hindu and Islamic culture, which had started under the Delhi Sultanate, almost reached its peak under Mughals. It was popularly known as **composite** culture or **Ganga-Jamuni** culture or **Hindustani** culture.

	Delhi Sultanate	Mughal Empire
Religious Pluralism	- Coexistence of Hinduism and Islam gradually led to exchange of ideas, mutual respect and emergence of shared cultural ethos at both elite as well as popular level. <i>Eg Chishti Sufi saints, Nirguni Bhakti movement, Lal Ded in Kashmir</i>	- Din-i-Ilahi, Sulh-e-Kul, Bhakti/Sufi movement. - Emergence of Sikhism was the great example of composite culture.
Architectural Synthesis	- Islamic elements blended with indigenous Hindu-Jain features resulting in the creation of Indo-Islamic styles. <u>Tughlaq architecture combined arches with trabeated beam/lintel structure.</u> - Motifs: lotus and the crescent moon. <u>Emergence of cities with Moorish character</u> and patronage was important for emergence of composite culture.	- Indian regional idiom and motifs and decorative features – kalash, chhatri, jharokha, lotus etc. - Akbar used trabeate style for secular buildings while arcuate style for religious. - Liberal adoption of Hindu motifs in buildings like the use of Swastika and lotus at Akbar's tomb, Sikandara
Literary Confluence	Persian literature and calligraphy flourished alongside vernacular languages like Awadhi and Braj Bhasha. Amir Khusro's compositions. Bhakti and Sufi literature played a significant role in bridging linguistic and cultural divides.	- Large number of Hindus learnt Persian language of court/revenue. - Akbar's translation department translated many Sanskrit books to Persian. Anwar-i-Suhaili (Translation of Panchatantra). - Mughal kings also patronized Sanskrit scholars - like Panditraj

	• Emergence of Urdu is the best example of it. Two styles of Hindavi - one in Devnagari one in Nastaliq.	Jagannath, Kavindracharya Saraswati • Dara Shikoh translated Upanishads to Persian. • Ras Khan (1548-1628) composed Rachnavali, a collection of poems on Krishna in Khariboli. • Urdu became the soul of north India.
Painting		• Assimilation of Indian, Persian, European elements in Mughal style of paintings... • Akbar patronized painting by establishing the Tasveer Khana where artists of all faiths and background assembled and worked. Here one finds an adaptation of Indian religious themes for paintings (eg Razmanama - Mahabharat) and profuse use of Indian peacock blue colour. • The European influence is visible with the use of light and shadow effect and miniatures. • So much identified with India that it became part of national painting during freedom movement.
Music and Dance		• Persian musical elements fused with Indian music, giving rise to new forms. Rise of Hindustani music soon started to flourish. <u>Dhrupad, Khyal, Thumri, Ghazal, Qawwali</u> etc became representative of Indian music. There was also prevalence of instruments like <u>sitar, sarangi and table</u>. The tradition from the court of Mansingh of Gwalior was taken to new heights gradually as Khyal gayaki became important. Tansen has also been credited with improvements in Rabab a Central Asian musical instrument. • Kathak dance: Radha-Krishna - Temple to Court dance
Cuisine		• Persian, Turkish, and Central Asian culinary influences merged with local Indian flavors and ingredients. • Samosa, Kebab, Yakhni, Firni, Jalebi, Pulao, Biryani became Indianized. • Gulab Jamun is a typical Perso-Arabic desert which is also Indian in its form. • Increasing role of bakery etc.

Thus, the idea of composite culture underscores the shared cultural heritage that fostered mutual understanding, served as a unifying force and left a lasting impact on the socio-cultural fabric of India.

Q. Discuss the significance of the Vijayanagara Empire in the development of Indian culture.

OR

How did the Vijayanagara Empire shape and influence the cultural landscape of South India?

OR

"Art, Literature and sculpture reached a high level of development in the Vijayanagar empire".

Evaluate.

As a powerful cultural state, the Vijayanagara Empire (14th-16th c) significantly contributed to Indian culture in the fields of art, architecture, religion, and literature and significantly shaped the cultural landscape of south India. So much so that Hampi, its capital, is today a UNESCO World Heritage Site.

OR

Vijayanagara's power, prestige, prosperity as well extensive trade interactions with foreign civilizations made South India a cultural melting pot of diverse influences, including Dravidian, Indo-Islamic, and European elements. Such cultural amalgamation is evident in Vijayanagara art and architecture.

Religious/ sectarian Pluralism	- Both Shaiva and Vaishnava sects, as well as Dvita and Advaita schools were patronized by the rulers. - The endorsement of the Bhakti movement, and patronage to mutts/temples in Karnataka, Andhra and Tamil Nadu enriched the cultural milieu of South India. - Moreover, Muslims and Christians were accommodated with a spirit of coexistence. There was harmonious cultural atmosphere and remarkable openness.
Cultural Revival	- Vijayanagara was a custodian of indigenous cultural traditions. It revived ancient texts, religious practices, and performance arts. - Eg Vidyaranya's work on Indian philosophical tradition, Sayanacharya's commentary on Vedas.
Architecture and urban planning	- Construction of magnificent palaces and urban centres in Hampi set new standards in urban planning and design. - The Vijayanagara style combined of the Chalukya, Hoysala, Pandya and Chola styles which evolved earlier in the centuries. Its grand temples were laced with intricate carvings, and monumental gopurams. It assimilated various prior regional tradition and led it to the pinnacle of Dravidian architecture. - eg Virupaksha Temple, Vitthala Temple, Hazara Rama Temple in Hampi.
Temple as social centres	- Vijayanagara rulers built many grand temple complexes. These temples became centers of cultural, social, and economic activities. - Thei became the centre of community life by supporting education, art, music and social gatherings.
Sculpture	- Refined craftsmanship of bronze and stone sculptures. - The sculptures depict royal, religious, mythological, and everyday life scenes. - Large life-size figures of men, women, gods, and goddesses are common to many Vijayagara temples. Carving of large monolithic statues, such as the Sasivekalu Ganesha and Kadalekalu Ganesha at Hampi.

	Unique engravings of charging horses or hippogryphs (yali) and other elements of Hindu mythology.
Painting	- While paintings served as adjuncts to architecture, adorning the inner ceilings and walls of palaces, they also depicted scenes from Hindu mythology. - Eg. Lepakshi murals
Language, Literature	- Patronage to scholars and poets led to the growth of literary works in languages like Kannada, Telugu, Tamil, and Sanskrit. - The period produced hundreds of works on all aspects of Indian culture, religion, biographies, history, prabhandas (stories), music, grammar, poetics and medicine. - Notable literary figures like Chamarasa, Lakkhana Dandesha, Kumaravyasa, Tenali Raman, and Allasani Peddana. - Krishnadevaraya himself wrote Amuktamalyada (Telugu) and Jambavati Kalyanam (Sanskrit).
Music	- Vijayanagara Empire was a time of great musical innovation. - Scholarly work such as Sangita Kalanidhi was written by Kallinatha. - Haridasi musical tradition of Purandaradasa and Annamacharya infused the classical music with the element of Bhakti which eventually created Carnatic classical music.
Dance	- The Vijayanagara Empire was also a time of great dance innovation. In the temples, Devadasi nritya (later Bharatnatyam) as well as early phase of Kuchipudi dance evolved. - The temple sculptures of the era depict some intricate dance poses and mudras.

The rich cultural legacy of the Vijayanagara continued to shape the cultural landscape by influencing subsequent kingdoms such as Nayakas and Marathas.

OR

The rulers of Vijayanagar established a strong empire with strong and everlasting tradition of art which attracted many foreigners in past and continues to attract tourists even today and propagate the rich diverse heritage of India to the world.

Practice Question:

Q. Why is the Vijayanagar empire called the *cultural capital* of the south?

Q. Krishnadeva Raya, the King of Vijayanagar, was not only an accomplished scholar himself but was also a great patron of learning and literature. Discuss. (150 words, 10 Marks)

- **Accomplished scholar himself:**
 - Prodigious scholarship and literary acumen
 - Jambavati Kalyanam, Madalasa Charita etc. in Sanskrit
 - Amuktamalyada in Telugu
- **Great patron of learning and literature:**
 - Called himself **Abhinavabhoja**
 - As per Rayavachakamu, the king spent the day at court with full assembly of scholars, poets, and palace officers, skilled at telling pleasant stories.
 - **Inclusive patronage:** Sanskrit, Tamil, Kannada – yet ascendancy of Telugu as pre-eminent language of the empire.
 - Vernaculars received patronage on equal footing and remained prestigious.
 - Hariharadasa in Tamil, Lolla Lakshmidhara in Sanskrit, Vyasatirtha in Kannada.
 - **Epicentre:**
 - Asht-dig-gaja – great poets of the land invited to the court by KDR
 - Allasani Peddanna (poet laureate, close confidante) – most celebrated Telugu poet.
 - Nandi Timmana – most celebrated Parijata Apaharanamu
 - Tenali Raman – poet of wit (vikatakavi) (a la Birbal – Akbar – popular stories even today)
 - **Vasantotsavam:** annual spring festival – favourite gathering occasion of poets for celebration. Aspiring poets from far and wide arrived to the court for series of events.
 - **Tulapurusha rite:** king would weigh himself against gold and pearls and then distribute them to the learned Brahmins – KDR performed this on many occasions. Even today at Hampi the great Tulabharam can be seen.